authorities alleged that the BPP's armed units—and it had some—had burned schools, bombed bridges, and assassinated village headmen and police officers. Between September 1990 and September 1991, more than 2,000 pieces of firearms as well as hand grenades, land mines, and gelatine explosives were seized from rebels in the south.[40]

Regardless of which side was right, the violence led to an exodus of ethnic Nepalese from Bhutan. As many as 100,000 fled. However, India, the only country, apart from China, that shares a border with Bhutan, did not want them: relations with the government of the strategically important Bhutan were more important than concern over the plight of the Lhotshampas. The refugees continued flow into Nepal, where they were housed in a string of refugee camps in Jhapa and Morang near the Indian border in the south. There, some of the Lhotshampas became involved with politicians from Nepal's various communist parties, among them the Maoists. In the early 1970s, Jhapa had been the scene of a Maoist-led uprising similar to that in Naxalbari across the border in India. Inspired by their Nepalese comrades, some Lhotshampas even set up their own Maoist party.

Needless to say, such activities made it impossible for Bhutan to accept what Nepal and many western countries demanded: the right of the Lhotshampas to return to the homes they had left behind. Nor could the Indians ignore the warning signs from the camps in southern Nepal. The CIA had stated as early as 1965 that the separatist activities by the Lhotshampas could create a situation

> capable of exploitation by the Chinese, even though they have no direct access to the *duars* [foothills] which are geographically contiguous to India. One access could be through Sikkim, where China is rumoured to have agents. There are also about 1,000 Communist Party of India members—most of them Chinese-oriented—in the Darjeeling district of West Bengal who could also be used to infiltrate the *duars* and to encourage subversion.[41]

There was no way back for the Lhotshampa refugees, and, despite several rounds of talks between Bhutan and Nepal, they were destined to remain in their squalid camps in Jhapa and Morang for many years to come. In Bhutan, those Lhotshampas who remained became careful not to engage in any anti-government activities. They knew the response would be expulsion from the kingdom.